played in just four countries. I brought this and other examples of unworthy candidates to the notice of the then minister of sports, Uma Bharati, and told her that I considered it a farce to be included in the same list of nominees who have not even represented their country. It was as if the Arjunas had been given away like prasad, to any and everybody, ignoring those who truly deserve them.

I firmly refused the award because the selection committee had ignored the fundamental premise on which it was founded, and that by giving me the award at this stage it did not recognize 'the stature of the services I had rendered to the nation'. If her government had wanted to give me an award, why didn't they separate my name from the general list, and announce that they were honouring me with a lifetime achievement award? Moreover, why has it taken so long for my achievements to be acknowledged and recognized? After all, I had received a Padma Shri at the height of my career, when I was 'Asia's Best Athlete' and the 'Nation's Pride'. My refusal made headline news, but as far as I was concerned, if the government had wanted to offer me an Arjuna, why did it take them forty years?

Besides the Padma Shri, my other awards included the Helms World Trophy for the best athlete in the world presented by the United States of America in 1959, and the Indira Priyadarshini Gandhi Award in 1997. Such awards and decorations play a major role in boosting a sportsman's morale, they bring fame and immortalize a person's name, but unfortunately very few of them bring great financial benefits. In the early years of the Arjuna Award, sportspeople received a sum of money, but few benefits, unlike today when awardees are entitled to railway passes, discounted airfares, petrol and gas agencies, among others.

I have always been a strong advocate for the cause of continuing official patronage for prominent sportspeople when they retire. Most sportspeople come from indigent, uneducated backgrounds, whose parents neither had the means nor the influence to develop their child's potential. But what differentiated these children from the rest was their hunger and drive to develop their abilities and succeed .

But what happens when they retire? They have no family money or assets to fall back on, and their brief careers have not provided them with a secure future; they receive no benefits or any monetary gain, and once they leave the field, they are forgotten. There have been so many tragic stories of